

El Hajj Chehade, Saiid

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Education

EPFL

PhD in Computer Science

Lausanne, Switzerland

Sep 2023 – Present

- Security and Privacy Field. Specializing in Web and Browser Privacy and Security.
- EDIC Fellowship Recipient.
- **Advisor:** Prof. Carmela Troncoso.

American University of Beirut

B.E. in Computer and Communication Engineering

Beirut, Lebanon

Aug 2019 – Jun 2023

- Minor in Applied Mathematics. Graduated with High Distinction (GPA: 4.23/4.0).
- Dean's Honor List (all semesters), Merit Scholarship (3rd in Lebanese national secondary exams).
- **Final Year Project:** Decentralized private polling system using threshold homomorphic encryption and touch-biometric authentication.

Publications

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Florian Hantke, and Ben Stock. 403 Forbidden? Ethically Evaluating Broken Access Control in the Wild. In *IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (S&P)*, 2025 [📄 github.com/Saiid2001/vsf](https://github.com/Saiid2001/vsf)

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Ben Stock, and Carmela Troncoso. Double-edged shield: On the fingerprintability of customized ad blockers. In *USENIX Security Symposium*, 2025 [📄 github.com/spring-epfl/flfp](https://github.com/spring-epfl/flfp)

Saiid El Hajj Chehade, Sandra Siby, and Carmela Troncoso. Sinbad: Saliency-informed detection of breakage caused by ad blocking. In *IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (S&P)*, 2024 [📄 github.com/spring-epfl/sinbad](https://github.com/spring-epfl/sinbad)

Work in Progress / Under Submission

Saiid El Hajj Chehade and Name Coauthor. Example title: Your work in progress paper. Under submission, 2025

Talks & Presentations

2025	Workshop Talk , Stealthy Fingerprinting Users with personalized blocking rules, Ad-Filtering Dev Summit 2025	Limassol, Cyprus
2025	Invited Talk , Customized Ad-blocker fingerprinting, New York University (NYU)	Brooklyn, NY, USA
2025	Invited Talk , Browser Vendor Fingerprinting, Max-Planck Institute for Security and Privacy (MPI-SP)	Bochum, Germany
2024	Invited Talk , Web Breakage Detection, DuckDuckGo Research Team	Remote
2024	Invited Talk , Web Breakage Detection, Brave Browser Research Team	Remote

Research Experience

Research Assistant

SPRING Lab – EPFL

Lausanne, Switzerland

Sep 2023 – Present

- Conducting research at the intersection of web measurement, web privacy, and browser security under Prof. Carmela Troncoso.

Research Consultant

Terre Des Hommes (NGO)

Lausanne, Switzerland

Mar 2025 – Mar 2026

- Analyzed a new online system deployment for security and privacy gaps through systems analysis and stakeholder interviews.
- Produced a report outlining vulnerabilities and actionable recommendations for the organization.

Research Intern

Brave Browser and Imperial College London

London, United Kingdom

Jun 2025 – Aug 2025

- Collaborated with Prof. Hamed Haddadi and the Brave research team on optimized page representations for text-based web agents used in large-scale security and privacy web measurements.
- Produced a middle layer between DOM and Accessibility tree that preserves semantic meaning in the page.
- Validated findings during internship; continuing with an upcoming academic submission.

MARCH 30, 2026

Visiting Researcher

Secure Web Application Group – CISPA

St. Ingbert, Germany

Jul 2024 – Sep 2024

- Collaborated with Prof. Ben Stock on unsafe parameters and authorization issues in HTTP requests for authenticated sessions.
- Developed a mirrored browser setup for synchronized requests from two controlled user accounts.
- Managed a group of 5 volunteers for large-scale semi-manual experiments.

Undergraduate Research Assistant

American University of Beirut

Beirut, Lebanon

Sep 2022 – Jan 2023

- Worked with Prof. Ibrahim Issa on fairness in machine learning; formulated problem statement and research direction.
- Compiled literature review and prepared a report detailing a taxonomy, directions, and a new definition for fairness.

Research Intern

SPRING Lab – EPFL

Lausanne, Switzerland

Jun 2022 – Aug 2022

- Proposed a differential DOM tree comparison algorithm and redefined the web-breakage problem definition, leading to a published paper (SINBAD, IEEE S&P 2024).
- Built a classification pipeline for web-page breakages to improve ad-blocker usability, achieving accuracy comparable to state-of-the-art.
- Published a USENIX Artifact for WebGraph (smart ad classifier) under supervision of Dr. Sandra Siby.
- Released the first open-source ad-block-enabled web crawling tool (Saiid2001/OpenWPM).

Research Assistant

American University of Beirut

Beirut, Lebanon

Sep 2020 – Dec 2021

- Led an HCD research project with Prof. Hazem Hajj on solving students' social needs in online education.
- Developed a full virtual campus platform (ElectronJS/Flask) with a mesh-topology conference interface using WebRTC.

Industry Experience

Lead Full Stack Engineer

Test Prep Institute

Beirut, Lebanon

May 2022 – Sep 2023

- Led a team of three to build an online educational platform; implemented automated testing and reduced student processing time by 70%.
- Architected a secure assessment environment with adaptive questions, access control, and live exam statistics.
- Collaborated with UN agencies to administer online entrance exams for 1000+ prospective instructors.

Blockchain Security Consultant

NiftyCraft

Remote, UAE

Jan 2022 – Aug 2022

- Designed and audited smart contracts for NFT-based authentication and access control mechanisms.
- Implemented token-gated content serving with on-chain verification, deployed to production.

Teaching

COM-301 **Fall '23, '24, '25**, Teaching Assistant for Introduction to Computer Security

EPFL, Switzerland

CS-523 **Spring '25**, Teaching Assistant for Advanced Topics in Privacy Enhancing Technologies

EPFL, Switzerland

Supervised Students

Fall '25 **Master Semester Project**, Alexandre Dunoyer de Segonzac, Deep Advertisement Scanning and Clustering

EPFL, Switzerland

Spring '24 **Master Semester Project**, Julien Mettler, Systematic evaluation of logged-in cookie sensitivity

EPFL, Switzerland

Spring '24 **Master Semester Project**, Jonas Gloning, Evaluating the privacy impact of Chrome V3 on web extensions

EPFL, Switzerland

Fall '24 **Master Semester Project**, Pierre-Louis Bravais, Automated agents for web measurements

EPFL, Switzerland

Fall '24 **Master Semester Project**, Siim Markus Marvet, Investigating Server-side Google Tag Manager

EPFL, Switzerland

Awards & Honors

2023 **EDIC Fellowship**, School of Computer Science, EPFL

Switzerland

2023 **Fellowship**, Summer Research Institute

Switzerland

2019–2023 **7x Dean's Honor List**, American University of Beirut

Lebanon

2019 **AUB / CNRS Merit Scholarship**, 3rd rank in Lebanese national secondary education exams

Lebanon

2019 **Prime Minister Honor Award**, Awarded for academic excellence in secondary education

Lebanon

Service & Outreach

2026	PC Member , MADWeb 2026 (co-located with NDSS)	
2024– Present	PhD Application Mentor , RAMP Program, EPFL	<i>Lausanne, Switzerland</i>
Nov 2022	Linux Workshop Instructor , Robotics Club, American University of Beirut (50 students) Kids Robotics Workshop , Organized robotics course for 20 children; prepared curriculum	<i>Beirut, Lebanon Chehim, Lebanon</i>

Skills & Languages

Programming	Python (Pandas, TensorFlow, NumPy, Scikit-learn, Spacy), C/C++, JavaScript, SQL, Java, CUDA, Django
Tools	Linux, Bash, $\text{\LaTeX}$, React, Docker, Git, Figma
Languages	English (Professional, IELTS 8.5), French (Bilingual, DELF B2), Arabic (Native)